MAICON

FORWARD

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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

From Ideas to Action: The Themes That Will Shape What Comes Next

Date & time: Oct. 15, 2:25-3:10 PM
Track: Keynote



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Session Description

After three days of ideas, experiments, predictions and real world lessons, Paul Roetzer and Mike Kaput close MAICON with a look at the ideas and questions that defined the week. The co-hosts of The Artificial Intelligence Show will surface the trends, tensions and recurring themes that defined MAICON 2026, from where organizations are making meaningful progress to the questions that still do not have easy answers. They will explore what changed in the AI conversation over the course of the conference, which ideas kept resurfacing, and what deserves more attention from leaders moving forward.

The session will leave attendees with a sharper sense of the questions they should be asking now, the priorities worth bringing back to their teams, and where to focus when they return to work.

Key Quote

> *"Just leave here, pick a thing that can make a difference in your career, your company, your kids' lives, whatever. And just go to work on it."* **- Paul Roetzer**
>
> *"Managers need to adapt to the new reality of what AI enables because you are increasingly, in some cases, being seen as a bottleneck rather than a facilitator."* **- Mike Kaput**

Session Summary

In the closing keynote of MAICON 2026, Paul Roetzer, Founder and CEO of SmarterX and Marketing AI Institute, and Mike Kaput, Chief Content Officer, revisited six questions about AI's impact on roles and skills that framed the conference. For each one, Kaput recapped what speakers and panelists said during the week, and Roetzer shared his own perspective.

1. How will current roles evolve?

Roetzer called the change disruptive: some roles, such as graphic design, may not be needed as much as they used to be. He believes leaders' first step should be to reskill people and move them into new roles rather than simply moving on from them, while acknowledging that not everyone will be a fit, such as a longtime graphic designer suddenly asked to design agent workflows. He compared the emerging AI architect to a strategist who can see across workflows and goals and reinvent a process entirely rather than just improve it, and described builders who can spin up several prototypes overnight for work that once took an outside firm months. He also pointed to an enterprise project manager of roughly 15 years whose institutional knowledge made them a natural fit for an AI-focused role, and said he expects a major evolution in roles by this time next year.

2. What new roles will emerge?

Kaput noted that AI transformation leaders and innovation specialists came up repeatedly during the week. Roetzer expects organizations to use different titles for these roles, and said renaming titles is awkward, especially in large companies, so most of the change will show up in job descriptions and responsibilities. Whether someone works in sales, customer success or marketing, creating and governing agents will become part of the job. He sees AI transformation as a hybrid: a centralized function focused on the highest-value initiatives, alongside empowering everyone to innovate from the ground up. He has often heard of new roles being created for people already inside a company who took the initiative, such as someone who drove AI adoption in marketing and was then asked to do it for the whole organization.

3. What skills and traits will remain uniquely human?

Kaput summarized the week's theme as learning to ask better questions, choose smarter problems and recognize better answers, including verifying AI outputs. Roetzer said the ability to work with AI systems is a durable skill: knowing what to ask, judging whether the output is good, iterating on prompts efficiently and connecting the right data sources. His advice for careers mirrors his advice for startups: assume the models will keep getting smarter, and build value that grows as they do. He also emphasized curiosity, imagination, resiliency, flexibility and comfort with unlearning, noting that a skill that mattered six months ago may already be obsolete. He tells his kids never to let AI take their imagination, and supports his daughter's English class banning AI so students learn the craft and know what good looks like. Internally, anyone on his team can use AI, but they need to be able to defend their work in a 10-minute conversation full of hard "why" questions, because you cannot fake having done the work.

4. How will AI agents transform workflows and org charts?

Kaput said agents are starting to span departments rather than staying within marketing or sales, managing agents is becoming a core skill, and humans risk becoming the bottleneck. Roetzer offered a more measured view. Most large organizations are nowhere near the advanced examples shown on stage and are still teaching employees, and even their C-suites, to use AI assistants for basic tasks. He expects a long adoption curve similar to AI assistants, with most agents low on the autonomy spectrum, such as agents that send reports every Monday or

answer the five questions he would ask his CMO, CRO, CFO and COO every Sunday night. He is skeptical that banks or hospital systems will deploy fully autonomous, self-improving multi-agent systems within a year because of the risk. He admitted he has overestimated timelines before, recalling that in 2016 he expected AI to be widely figured out by 2020 and was off by about a decade. His prediction: day-to-day reality next year probably will not look that different, even though frontier capabilities will be far greater.

5. How will middle management be impacted?

Kaput said speakers described AI taking on more coordination and reporting work, and managers increasingly being seen as bottlenecks rather than facilitators. Roetzer agreed but said he has spent more time thinking about the impact on entry-level work, and that it is hard to make a blanket statement because manager roles vary widely. Senior, director-level people with 12 to 15 years of experience, institutional knowledge and deep domain expertise who become AI-forward can do most of the work the levels below them used to do. The greater risk falls on people with roughly three to seven years of experience who have not yet established expertise, mainly manage workloads and people, and are not advanced with AI. In his view, domain expertise, experience and AI fluency are the variables that matter most.

6. How will the role of entry-level employees change?

Kaput observed that AI fluency is creating opportunities for entry-level employees, who are being selected for more responsibility regardless of years of experience, even as AI reduces the tasks that newcomers traditionally learn from, which is why apprenticeships came up repeatedly. Roetzer told younger attendees they are off to a strong start. He said he is not confident which college majors will matter in one, three or ten years, and that he is not convinced anyone knows, noting that a leading economist advising the president laughed at the idea of AI displacing entry-level work. His advice: whatever you are passionate about, from philosophy to engineering to design, be the best at using AI in that field responsibly. His concern is for the many people outside the room who do not know what attendees know, so he encouraged everyone to support entry-level workers and bring them along.

Closing question: What do we do about it?

Roetzer said the best path forward is using AI responsibly, understanding its risks and ethical concerns, and bringing both the next generation and our peers along. He encouraged attendees to pull the thread on whatever AI topic interests them. Echoing advice he gives his own kids, he said that when something is hard, you just do the next thing: leave MAICON, pick one thing that can make a difference in your career, your company or your kids' lives, go to work on it, and give yourself grace.

Key Takeaways

- **Reskill before you replace:** Roetzer urged leaders to start by reskilling existing team members and moving them into new roles before moving on from them.
- **Responsibilities will change faster than titles:** Expect job descriptions in every function to grow to include creating and governing agents, rather than sweeping title changes.

- **You have to be able to defend the work:** Using AI is fine, but people still need to explain and stand behind the thinking, because you cannot fake having done the work.
- **Expect a long, gradual agent curve:** Most organizations will start with low-autonomy agents that automate existing workflows, such as recurring reports, rather than fully autonomous systems.
- **Expertise plus AI fluency is the advantage:** Deep domain expertise and institutional knowledge combined with strong AI skills will matter most for managers and entry-level workers alike.
- **Pick one thing and do the next thing:** Leave with one priority that can make a difference in your career, company or family, go to work on it, and give yourself grace.